also had only four toilets, that meant just eight latrines for so many people. They must know that this was insufficient.

At the front gate, people were waiting in line to speak with the guards. An older woman complained that the soup was too watery, and her daughter, six months pregnant, needed protein. A man asked for a pair of shoes because his had been stolen overnight. The guard shrugged and waved them off. Finally, it was Léa's turn. Straightening her shoulders, she advanced to the desk.

"I arrived last night and was assigned to cabin F, but it's full. Please, will you assign me to a bed in another cabin?"

"Cabin F?" He rubbed his chin, taking a ledger from the shelf. His index finger ran down the page until it came to a sudden stop, and the gendarme made a grunting sound. "Cabin M," he said, looking over the ledger to meet her eyes, "has become vacant overnight." He dipped his pen in ink. "Your name?"

"Léa Cotillard." She stood.

"Mademoiselle Cotillard." He snapped the book shut. "The food rations are slim, clothing is insufficient, especially in winter. And there's no point in complaining about anything." He cleared his throat, a lewd glint in his eyes. "But if you need special assistance, perhaps we could come to an understanding."

Léa blinked, fighting to keep the disgust from her face. She understood what he was intimating—and a surge of defiance made her want to tell him she wouldn't be coming back for anything. But she needed that bed, so she swallowed her pride and let it go.

As Léa approached the cabin, she saw a small group of women gathered outside, some of them crying.

"What's wrong?" Léa asked.

A woman, bone-thin, pointed at the stairs. Léa turned to see two guards carrying a stretcher with a body covered by a blanket.

"Poor Simone," the woman sobbed. "I thought she was tired and decided to let her sleep in, but when I came back with some bread from breakfast—" she sucked in a breath "—her body was cold and stiff. She died in the night."

"I'm sorry. Had she been ill for a while?"

"Ill?" The woman scowled. "It's been two months since we've had